Effects on wildlife

Plastics pose many dangers to wildlife. Larger items such as plastic shopping bags can choke or strangle birds and marine animals; if ingested, they can damage their digestive tracts or obstruct the stomach, causing starvation. If microplastics are ingested, toxins can pass into an animal's fatty tissues, a process that then passes up the food chain.

According to scientists, an estimated 32 percent of turtles have plastic in their stomachs, 56 percent of marine mammals have ingested plastic, and about 90 percent of seabirds have eaten plastic. Even some of the crustaceans living in the western Pacific's Mariana Trench, the deepest point in the world's oceans, are known to have ingested plastic.

Companies are starting to take the need to reduce plastic use seriously. A brewer in Florida, for instance, has found a way to make six-pack rings from by-products of the brewing process, so that seabirds can chew them off if they become caught in them.